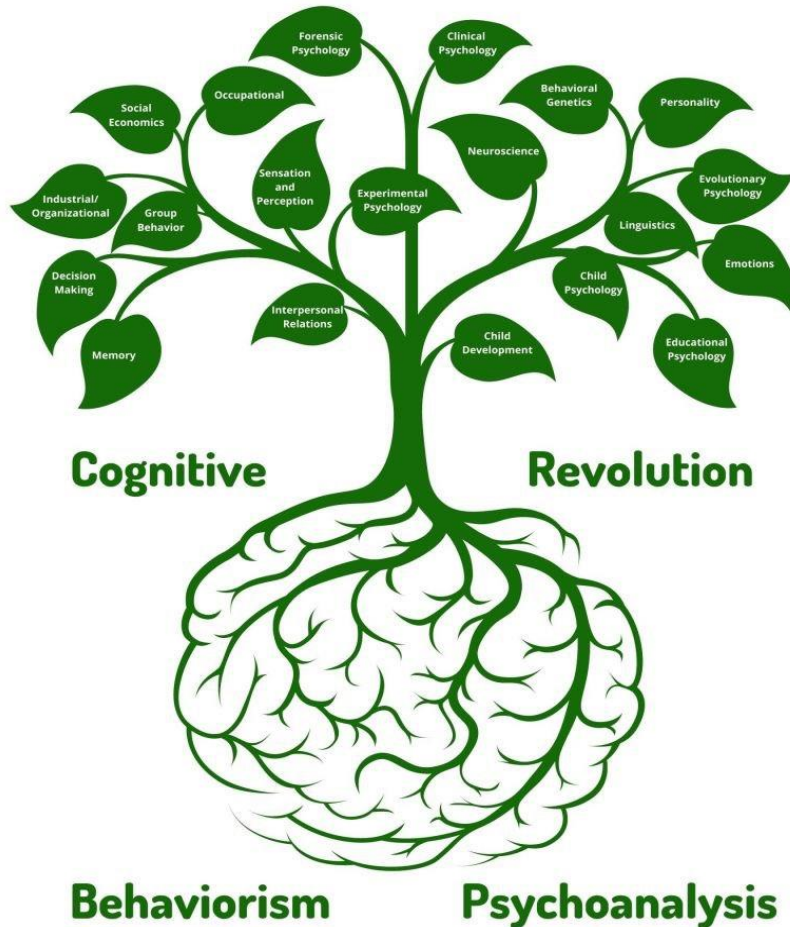




Chapter 2

Major perspectives in the historical develop ment of psychology

Psychology broke away from **philosophy and **physiology** and emerged as a separate discipline over 100 years ago.**

In the last century, this young and fertile discipline went through a series of changes

1- Structuralism:



- Formal research in psychology began at the university of Leipzig Germany where Wilhelm Wundt founded the first psychological laboratory in 1879.
- Wundt is considered as the first psychologist and father of experimental psychology.

- He limited the subject matter of psychology to the study of conscious experience. The elements of conscious experience were considered to be of two kinds. These are: **Sensations:** sights, sounds, tastes, smells and touch, which arise from stimulation of the sense organs. **Feelings:** love, fear, joy, and so on.

2- Functionalism:

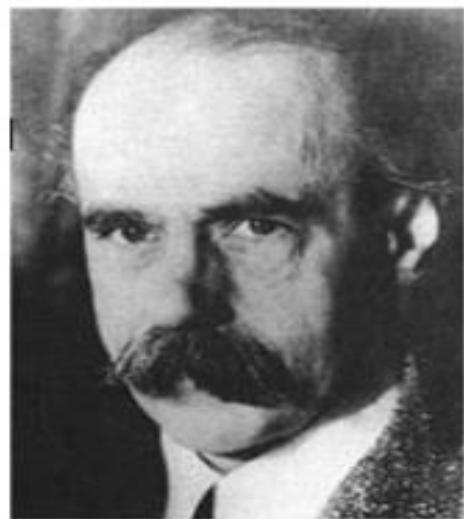


- The American psychologist William James pioneered functionalism.
- It focused on what the mind does on the functions of mental activity and the role of behavior in allowing people to adapt to their environment.

- Functionalism was strongly **influenced by biology**. The work and ideas of **Charles Darwin** had a great impact on the emergence of functional psychology. According to Darwin's theory of evolution, living organisms change and develop over time through a process of natural selection. Organisms whose characteristics were best suited to their environment survived and reproduced. While organisms whose characteristics were less adaptable died out. Survivors would transmit to the next generation those characteristics that enabled them to survive.

- William James was greatly influenced by Darwin. James held that the function of consciousness was to enable humans to behave in ways that would act survival through adaptation to the environment. Where these adaptive behaviors were repeated frequently, they became habits. Habits provide stability and predictability in society.

3- Gestalt psychology:



Max Wertheimer
1880 -1943



Wolfgang Kohler
1887 - 1967



Kurt Koffka
1886 - 1941

- The leading proponents of the Gestalt view were the German psychologists Max Wertheimer, Kurt Kafka, and Wolfgang Kohler.

- Gestalt psychologists concentrated on the whole'. **Their slogan is 'the whole is greater than the sum of its parts'**. Gestalt means shape, form, or configuration.
- Their belief was that the whole is different from the sum of its parts. To understand our environment, **we must perceive it in its totality not in its individuality**. Max Wertheimer said that **'it is a mistake to analyze psychological events into pieces, or elements, as the structuralists did.**

4- Psychoanalysis:



- The Viennese neurologist and psychologist Sigmund Freud (1856-1939) pioneered the psychoanalytic perspective.

- Freud said that conscious experiences are only the tip of the **Iceberg**. Beneath the conscious experience is Primitive biological urges that seek expression, but which conflict with the norms and morality of the society.
- **These unconscious motivations and conflicts have powerful influences on our conscious thoughts and actions.** Therefore, they are responsible for much of human behavior including physiological problems. **According to Freud, all behavior whether normal or abnormal is influenced by the unconscious mind.** This belief is called **psychic determinism**.

According to Freud the methods of studying the unconscious mind are:

a. Free association:

- In this method the psychoanalyst gives the client a word and asks to reply with the first word that comes to mind be it nonsense or irrelevant. The psychoanalyst makes associations and meanings between ideas, words, and thought.
 - It is a projective technique to explore the client's unconscious thoughts.
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b. Dream analysis based on case studies:

- The contents of dreams are analyzed for underlying or hidden motivations.
- Dreams are viewed as indication of what a person is truly feeling within the conscious mind. Freud said dreams are **'the royal road to the understanding of the unconscious.**

5- Behaviorism:



John B. Watson

- John Watson (1878-1958) revolutionized psychology by changing the subject matter of psychology from the study of conscious experience to the study of behavior.

- Watson believed that the study of psychology should be about **observable behavior** and its aim should be to **describe, predict, understand, and control behavior.**
- He contended that psychologists should never use the terms consciousness, mental states, introspection, imagery, and the like.
- Followers of behaviorism did not reject the existence of mind and consciousness. Rather, **they viewed these concepts as impossible to observe and contributing little to a scientific approach to psychology.**

- Watson's focus on the study of observable behavior enabled to formulate clear hypotheses, which could be tested by experimentation.
- Watson's view of learning relied to a great extent on Pavlov's account of classical conditioning. Accordingly, it is possible to break down and analyze a certain behavior into stimulus-response units.

Recent perspectives

1- The biological perspective:

It states that behavior has a biological basis. The behavior of both people and animals should be considered in terms of biological functioning. Topics that are discussed in this perspective include:

- How are the individual nerve cells joined together?
- How heredity influences behavior?
- What are the physiological responses when a baby confronts a stranger?

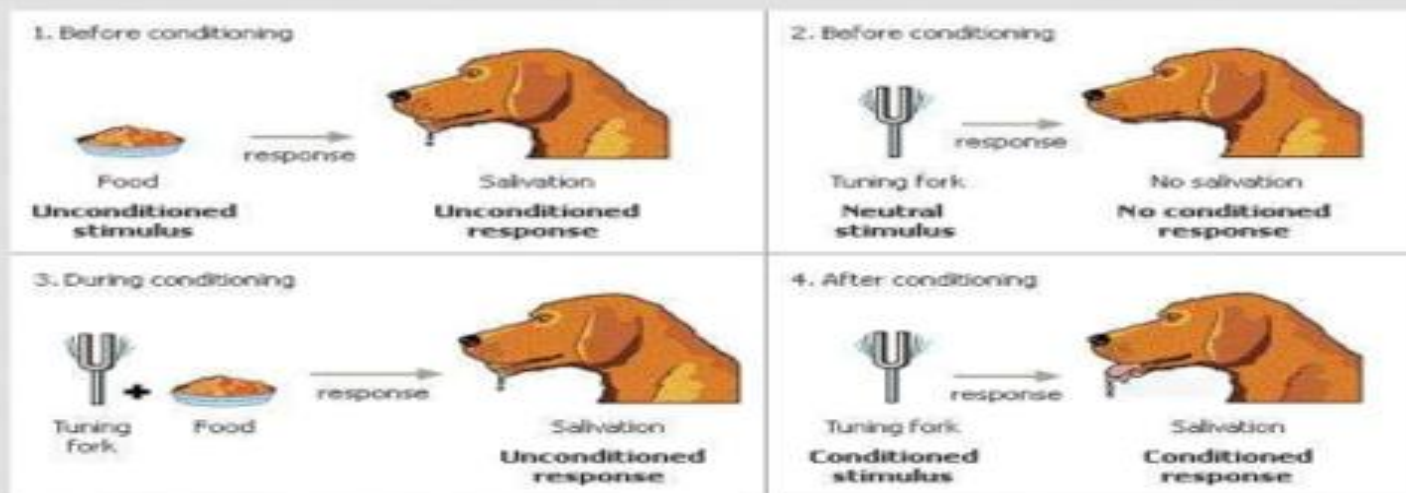
2- The cognitive perspective

- It focuses on the process that helps people to know, understand, and think about the world.
- This perspective explains how information in the memory is processed at different stages and how our thinking about the world influences our behavior.

3- The behavioral perspective:

- The 1904 Nobel Prize winner, the Russian physiologist and psychologist, **Ivan Pavlov** opened a new way of thinking for psychological.
- His experiment on dogs enabled psychologists to explain certain behavior and certain differences among individuals as the result of learning.

PAVLOV'S EXPERIMENT



- Following the works of Pavlov, Thorndike and Watson behaviorism got strength. Through time, its principles and methods of study became an integral part of psychology.

- The American psychologist **B.F. Skinner** refined and popularized behaviorism. He showed that the **consequences** of behavior provide the basic mechanism for **predicting** and **shaping** future behavior.

Contribution: Skinner's theory inspired certain techniques of toilet training how to lose weight, quit smoking and learn new skills. His theory helped to develop techniques for the treatment of various psychological disorders, the resolution of sexual problems and even the halting of drug addiction.

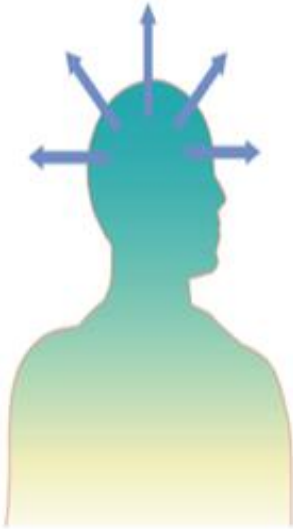
4- The humanistic perspective:

- It is a psychological approach that suggests that people are in control of their lives.
 - This perspective assumes that people are naturally endowed with the capacity to make decisions about their lives and to control their behavior.
 - Humanistic psychologists claim that everyone has the capacity to develop to higher levels of maturity and realize his/her full potential if given the opportunity.
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Neuroscience

Views behavior from the perspective of biological functioning



Psychodynamic

Believes behavior is motivated by inner, unconscious forces over which a person has little control



Behavioral

Focuses on observable behavior



Cognitive

Examines how people understand and think about the world



Humanistic

Contends that people can control their behavior and that they naturally try to reach their full potential

